Module 6: Effective Communication and Stakeholder Management

Detailed supplement: the deck topics the handbook module extends, with worked examples, a rewrite exercise and an assignment

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MODULE 6 · HOW TO USE THIS SUPPLEMENT

Coverage map: what is new and what is already in the module

Read this supplement next to the main Module 6 handbook. **Extended** means the handbook has the topic and this PDF adds the deck's example or template. **New** means the handbook did not have it. Examples with numbers are hypothetical, as the deck labels them.

Topic	Handbook section	Status here
Answer first: Pyramid Principle and SCQA	6.2	Extended: one full worked example from a checkout problem
Storytelling with data	6.3	Extended: title = takeaway; chart choice rules
Communication map: idea to general availability	—	New: the product stage map and what to write at each stage
Layers of communication	—	New: immediate team, stakeholders, upward, outer circle
Power–interest stakeholder map	6.4	Extended: how to re-map as the project changes
RACI and DACI	6.5	Extended: a worked role table for one decision
Influence without authority	6.4	New: five levers with examples
Negotiation: positions vs interests	6.6	Extended: a worked sales-vs-product example
Five conflict modes and a five-step sequence	6.6	Extended: when to use each mode
Decision meeting anatomy	6.7	Extended: the timed agenda and the record
PRD sections	6.8	Extended: eight sections in order
Engineering scope negotiation dialogue	6.9	New: a worked dialogue and the four rules
Difficult stakeholder patterns	6.11	Extended: a response table
SBI feedback and the feedback loop	6.13	Extended: a worked SBI sentence
Executive reviews and bad news	6.14	New: five-sentence bad-news structure
Rewrite exercise with model answer	6.15	New: the rewrite with a model answer
Week 6 assignment	6.15	New: three-part brief

NOTE ON THE SOURCE

Some deck slides have labels only (for example, the layers of communication diagram). Only the labels are used here, and the text does not invent detail beyond them.

NEW · COMMUNICATION MAP

Communication follows the product stage

The deck's communication map links each stage of a product to its goal and to the documents that carry the message. Communicate more often and more formally as the stage gets closer to launch.

Stage	Goal of the stage	Typical documents and updates
Idea	Test the hypothesis	Research doc, progress notes, learnings
MVP	Test the hypothesis with a small group	PRD, project wiki, metrics updates
Early launch	Test product-market fit with a wider base	GTM plan, experiment plan, more updates
General availability	Plan to overcome the remaining obstacles	Launch review, support briefing, metrics against targets

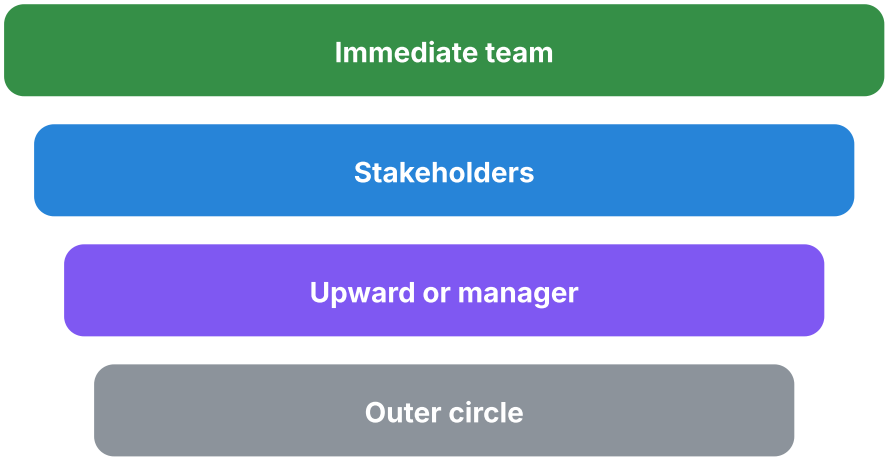
The deck's strategy: build and launch iteratively, so that each stage builds on what the last one proved.

NEW · LAYERS OF COMMUNICATION

Who hears what, and how often

The deck shows communication as layers around the PM. The labels are: **immediate team** (daily and weekly, the people who build), **stakeholders** (regular updates, the people who decide scope), **upward or manager level** (short, decision-focused updates), and the **outer circle** (occasional, outcome-focused updates for the wider company).

Match the level to the decision. A change to the team's sprint goes to the immediate layer. A change to launch timing goes up one layer and reaches the outer circle when it affects customers.



Layers of communication

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.2

Answer first: a worked checkout example

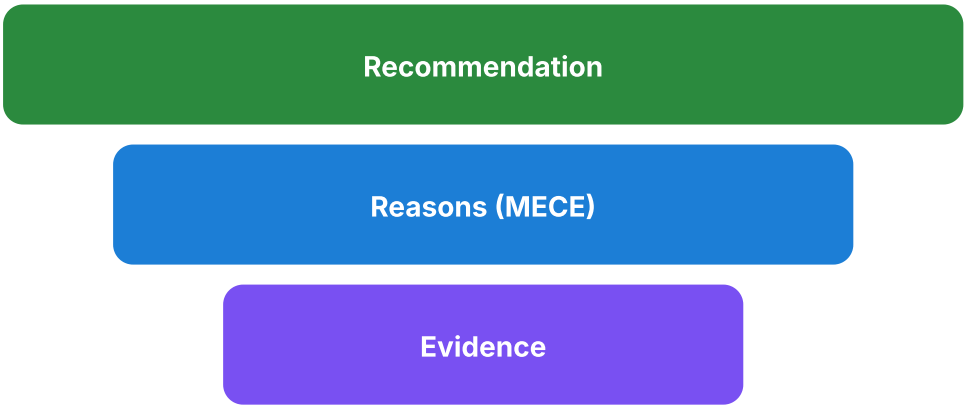
Lead with the governing thought, then group the reasons so that they do not overlap and leave no gap (the deck calls this MECE). Support each reason with evidence. A leader can stop reading at any level and still have the point.

Level	Content (hypothetical example)
Recommendation	Show the delivery fee in the cart this quarter.
Reason 1: biggest leak	30 percent leave at payment.
Reason 2: why it happens	6 of 8 users interviewed cite the fee surprise.
Reason 3: cheap and low risk	About two person-months; behind a feature flag.
Reason 4: we can prove it	A 14-day A/B test, with a guardrail: complaints at or below 1.3 percent.

SCQA: how to open any update, memo or pitch

Part	What it does	Example
Situation	Shared, uncontroversial context	Checkout is our main conversion step.
Complication	What changed or what is wrong	Payment drop-off has risen.
Question	The question the complication raises	What would reduce the drop-off fastest?
Answer	Your recommendation, then the reasons	Show the fee in the cart and test it.

Use SCQA when the audience needs context first. Use the pyramid when they need the answer first.



The pyramid: answer first, then reasons, then evidence

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.3

Storytelling with data

Make the title the takeaway, not the chart's name: 'Checkout loses most users at payment' is better than 'Funnel Q1'. Choose the chart by the question: a trend uses a line, a comparison uses bars, and a distribution uses a histogram. Remove clutter, and highlight one thing with colour.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.5

RACI and DACI: a worked decision

RACI assigns work: **Responsible** does it, **Accountable** owns the outcome (one person), **Consulted** gives two-way input, and **Informed** is kept updated. DACI assigns a decision: the **Driver** runs the process, the **Approver** decides (one person), **Contributors** give input, and the **Informed** hear the result.

DACI role	Who (hypothetical example)
Driver	PM, checkout
Approver	Head of Product
Contributors	Design, engineering lead, analytics, payments, legal
Informed	Support, marketing, sales

Write the approver down before the debate starts. One approver per decision prevents most escalations.

NEW · INFLUENCE WITHOUT AUTHORITY

Five levers that work

Lever	What it looks like
Shared goals	'We both want fewer failed payments.' Start from the goal you share.
Evidence	Data, research and customer quotes beat opinions.
Reciprocity	Help others hit their goals too.
Early involvement	People defend what they helped write.
Follow-through	Do what you said. Credibility builds over time.

The deck adds one more: an **easy yes**, meaning a clear ask and a small first step.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.6

Positions versus interests

A position is what someone asks for. An interest is why they ask. Solve for interests, and the positions often change.

Party	Position (what they ask for)	Interest (why)
Sales	Build custom reports for one client by June.	Keep a large renewal; the client's finance team needs monthly numbers.
Product	Not this quarter; checkout comes first.	Hit the checkout goal; avoid one-off custom features.

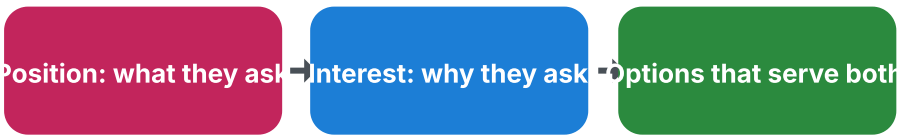
Options that serve both: a scheduled CSV export within two weeks, and a decision on custom reports in Q3, based on evidence from other clients.

The deck draws on Fisher and Ury's *Getting to Yes*: separate people from the problem, focus on interests, invent options, use objective criteria, and know your BATNA (your best alternative if no deal is reached).

Five conflict modes and a five-step sequence

Mode	Use it when
Collaborating	The issue is important and trust is high.
Compromising	The trade-off is time-bound.
Accommodating	The stakes are low and goodwill matters.
Competing	The call is urgent and clear-cut.
Avoiding	The issue is trivial.

1. Restate each side's interest until both agree you understood it.
2. Agree the shared goal and the decision criteria.
3. Lay out options with evidence.
4. Decide, or escalate together with a joint summary.
5. Document the decision and move on.



Solve for interests, not positions

NEW · ENGINEERING COLLABORATION

Negotiating scope with an engineering lead

The deck gives an illustrative dialogue. The PM starts from the goal, not the solution, then trades scope rather than quality.

Speaker	What they say
PM	Our goal is to stop the fee surprise for first-time buyers this quarter. What is the simplest version you would build?
Engineering lead	A static fee is easy. A live estimate needs the pricing service: three weeks, and it is unreliable at peak.
PM	What if v1 shows the estimate when the service replies within 500 ms, and 'estimate unavailable' otherwise?
Engineering lead	Then it is about ten days. We would add a cache later.
PM	Let's take that, behind a flag, as an A/B test. I will update the PRD and log the cache as a follow-up.

- Start with the goal, then ask for the simplest option.
- Ask for estimates as ranges with assumptions.
- Trade scope, not quality.
- Record the follow-up so it is not lost.
- Story points are planning tools, not productivity scores.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.11

Difficult stakeholders: patterns and responses

Pattern	Response
The HiPPO (highest paid person's opinion)	Ask for the goal behind the idea; propose a test; show data respectfully.
The bulldozer ('just build it')	Acknowledge the urgency; show the cost of delay to displaced work; offer a smaller slice.
The silent blocker	Hold a one-to-one; ask what would make them comfortable; involve them early.
The scope-creeper	Point to the agreed scope and the decision log; queue new asks for the next cycle.
The customer-promiser	Agree a rule: no commitments without PM sign-off. Share themes, not dates.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.7

Anatomy of a decision meeting

Stage	Time	What happens
Pre-read	48 hours before	A one-page brief: context, options and a recommendation
Frame	5 minutes	State the decision, the decider and the criteria
Options	15 minutes	Trade-offs and evidence for each option
Dissent	10 minutes	Ask 'what would make this wrong?'
Decide	5 minutes	Decide, or name the missing information
Record	24 hours after	Write the decision, rationale, owner and review date

Most of the work happens before and after the meeting. If nobody read the pre-read, read it together for the first five minutes.



Anatomy of a decision meeting

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.8

The PRD: eight sections in order

No.	Section	What to include
1	Summary and decision	Problem, proposal, impact, owner and status
2	Problem and evidence	Who, what task, why it is hard, data and quotes
3	Goals and metrics	Primary metric and target; guardrails
4	Users and use cases	Segments, key scenarios and edge cases
5	Scope	In and out of scope; assumptions
6	Requirements	User stories, acceptance criteria and non-functional needs
7	Design and analytics	Prototype links and a tracking plan
8	Launch and risks	Rollout, feature flags, rollback and open questions

WATCH OUT

Use AI for a first draft, never as the source of truth. Check every number, assumption and privacy detail before you share it.

User stories follow the form 'As a first-time buyer, I want to see my estimated total in the cart, so that I can decide before I start paying.' The deck's INVEST checklist asks that a story is Independent, Negotiable, Valuable, Estimable, Small and Testable.

EXTENDED · SECTION 6.13

SBI feedback and the feedback loop

Use SBI: **Situation**, **Behaviour**, **Impact**. For example: 'In yesterday's review (situation), the PRD's success metric changed from completion to clicks without a note (behaviour). Engineering built toward the old target, and two days were lost (impact).'

1. **Context:** be specific.
2. **Response:** listen fully.
3. **Action:** agree the next step.
4. **Close the loop:** confirm the outcome.

NEW · SECTION 6.14

Executive reviews and bad news

Executives want the decision you need, how it serves the strategy, metrics against targets with an honest green, amber or red, what you learned, and what you are not doing. Prepare answers to the three hardest questions first.

Bad news in five sentences

1. What happened, plainly.
2. The impact.
3. The cause, if known.
4. What you are doing, and what you need.
5. When you will update next.

EXAMPLE (HYPOTHETICAL)

'The launch will slip two weeks. A payment-gateway certification took longer than estimated. There is no customer-facing risk. I recommend waiting rather than launching without the new payment method. I will update you every Friday.'

NEW · EXERCISE

Rewrite this update

Original: 'We did lots of analysis this week. We looked at funnels, did interviews, talked to payments, and engineering thinks it's 2 months. Fees might be a problem. Also loyalty is pending.'

Rewrite it with the pyramid: the answer first, then two or three reasons with evidence, then the ask. Give yourself five minutes.

MODEL ANSWER (HYPOTHETICAL)

Recommendation: test showing the delivery fee in the cart from the next sprint. **Why:** (1) 30 percent of checkout starters leave at payment; (2) 6 of 8 interviewees cite the fee surprise; (3) a simplified v1 takes about two weeks, and the full live estimate about two months. **Ask:** approve the two-week v1 and an A/B test; move loyalty to Q3.

ASSIGNMENT

Week 6 assignment: three parts

1. **Executive summary:** write a one-screen summary for a product change you would recommend, in any app you use.
2. **Stakeholder map:** place six stakeholders on a power–interest grid, and write one action for each.
3. **Acceptance criteria:** write three Given/When/Then criteria for 'saved addresses'.

SELF-CHECK

Is the answer first? Does each reason come with evidence? Is every stakeholder's action specific? Does each criterion test one behaviour?

Quiz with answers

1. What does the pyramid principle ask you to put first?
   Answer: the governing thought or recommendation, then the supporting reasons.
2. In DACI, who decides?
   Answer: the Approver, one person.
3. What is the difference between a position and an interest?
   Answer: a position is what someone asks for; an interest is why they ask.
4. Which conflict mode fits an urgent, clear-cut call?
   Answer: competing.
5. In SBI, what does the B stand for?
   Answer: Behaviour.
6. How many sentences does the bad-news structure use?
   Answer: five.

MODULE 6 · FINAL

Completion checklist

Completion checklist

Done	Item
☐	Read the coverage map and marked the new topics
☐	Built one pyramid recommendation for a product you use
☐	Mapped stakeholders with a power–interest grid
☐	Wrote a DACI for one decision
☐	Rewrote the update exercise
☐	Completed the three-part assignment
☐	Answered the quiz without notes